

Κερκίδας ὁ Μεγαλοπολίτης

Cercidas of Megalopolis and Cynic Satire in Verse

eul_aid: ioi

Period: Ἑλληνιστική [Hellenistic](#)

Dialect: Δωρική [Doric \(frg\)](#)

Domain: Ποίησης [Poetry](#)

Format: Ἑμμετρος [Verse](#)

Cercidas was a citizen of Megalopolis in ancient Greece during the 3rd century BCE. He lived in the Hellenistic period, a time of great political change following the death of Alexander the Great. His public life was dual in nature, encompassing both practical statesmanship and philosophical poetry.

He served as an envoy and lawgiver for the Achaean League, actively involved in the military and political affairs of his era. As a writer, Cercidas is associated with the Cynic school of philosophy. He is best known for a collection of poems called the Meliambi, written in a mixed meter known as lyric iambs. These poems survive only in fragments. They employed a blunt, often humorous style to deliver social criticism and moral lessons, targeting themes like wealth, hypocrisy, and foolishness common to Cynic thought.

According to modern scholars, his innovative poetic style shows the influence of earlier poets and is considered a forerunner to later satirical traditions. Cercidas is significant as a figure who bridged philosophy, poetry, and politics. His work provides insight into how Cynic ideas were disseminated through popular literature outside major cultural centers. His life presents a complex portrait of a Hellenistic intellectual who was simultaneously a pragmatic political actor and a moralizing poet.

Works (1)

- Ἀποσπάσματα τῆς Κυνικῆς Σατύρας · [Fragments of Cynic Satire](#) · 109 passages